

Deep vein thrombosis (DVT) — Symptoms & causes

Source: Mayo Clinic

Overview

Deep vein thrombosis (DVT) occurs when a blood clot (thrombus) forms in one or more of the deep veins in the body, usually in the legs. Deep vein thrombosis can cause leg pain or swelling. Sometimes there are no noticeable symptoms.

A blood clot in a leg vein may cause pain, warmth and tenderness in the affected area. You can get DVT if you have certain medical conditions that affect how the blood clots. A blood clot in the legs can also develop if you don't move for a long time, for example when traveling a long distance.

Symptoms

Deep vein thrombosis (DVT) symptoms can include:

- Leg swelling
- Leg pain, cramping or soreness that often starts in the calf
- Change in skin color on the leg — such as red or purple, depending on the color of your skin
- A feeling of warmth on the affected leg

Deep vein thrombosis can occur without noticeable symptoms.

When to see a doctor

If you develop symptoms of Deep vein thrombosis (DVT), contact your health care provider.

If you develop symptoms of a pulmonary embolism (PE) — a life-threatening complication of deep vein thrombosis — seek emergency medical help.

The warning signs and symptoms of a pulmonary embolism include:

- Sudden shortness of breath
- Chest pain or discomfort that worsens when you take a deep breath or cough
- Fainting
- Rapid pulse
- Rapid breathing
- Coughing up blood

A pulmonary embolism (PE) occurs when a blood clot gets stuck in an artery in the lung, blocking blood flow to part of the lung. Blood clots most often start in the legs and travel up through the right side of the heart and into the lungs. This is called deep vein thrombosis (DVT).

Causes

Anything that prevents the blood from flowing or properly clotting can cause a blood clot.

The main causes of deep vein thrombosis (DVT) are damage to a vein from surgery or inflammation and damage due to infection or injury.

Risk factors

A personal or family history of DVT or pulmonary embolism (PE). If you or someone in your family has had one or both of these conditions, you might be at greater risk of developing DVT.

Genetics. Some people have DNA changes that cause the blood to clot more easily. One example is factor V Leiden. This inherited disorder changes one of the clotting factors in the blood. An inherited disorder on its own might not cause blood clots unless combined with other risk factors.

Sometimes, a blood clot in a vein can occur with no identifiable risk factor. This is called an unprovoked venous thromboembolism.

Complications

Pulmonary embolism (PE). PE is a potentially life-threatening complication associated with DVT. It occurs when a blood clot (thrombus) in a leg or other body area breaks free and gets stuck in a blood vessel in a lung.

Get immediate medical help if you have symptoms of PE. They include sudden shortness of breath, chest pain while breathing in or coughing, rapid breathing, rapid pulse, feeling faint or fainting, and coughing up blood.

Postphlebitic syndrome. Damage to the veins from the blood clot reduces blood flow in the affected areas. Symptoms include leg pain, leg swelling, skin color changes and skin sores.

Treatment complications. Blood thinners are often used to treat DVT. Bleeding (hemorrhage) is a worrisome side effect of blood thinners. It's important to have regular blood tests while taking blood-thinning drugs.

Prevention

Lifestyle changes may help prevent deep vein thrombosis. Try these strategies:

Move your legs. If you've had surgery or have been on bed rest, try to move as soon as possible. Don't cross your legs while sitting. Doing so can block blood flow.

When traveling, take frequent breaks to stretch your legs. When on a plane, stand or walk occasionally. If you're traveling by car, stop every hour or so and walk around. If you can't walk, do lower leg exercises: raise and lower your heels while keeping your toes on the floor, then raise your toes while keeping your heels on the floor.

Don't smoke. Smoking increases the risk of DVT.

Manage weight. Obesity is a risk factor for DVT. Regular exercise lowers the risk of blood clots. As a general goal, aim for at least 30 minutes of moderate physical activity every day. If you want to lose weight, maintain weight loss or meet specific fitness goals, you may need to exercise more.

By Mayo Clinic Staff — Jun 11, 2022

Original source:

[mayoclinic.org/diseases-conditions/deep-vein-thrombosis/symptoms-causes/syc-20352557](https://www.mayoclinic.org/diseases-conditions/deep-vein-thrombosis/symptoms-causes/syc-20352557)